

something more challenging. HYROX now has given a very large population of gym-goers, who never had anything to look forward to in terms of fitness goals, a way to quantify how much they have progressed."

The HYROX will return to Mumbai in September, while Bengaluru will get its own race in April next year.

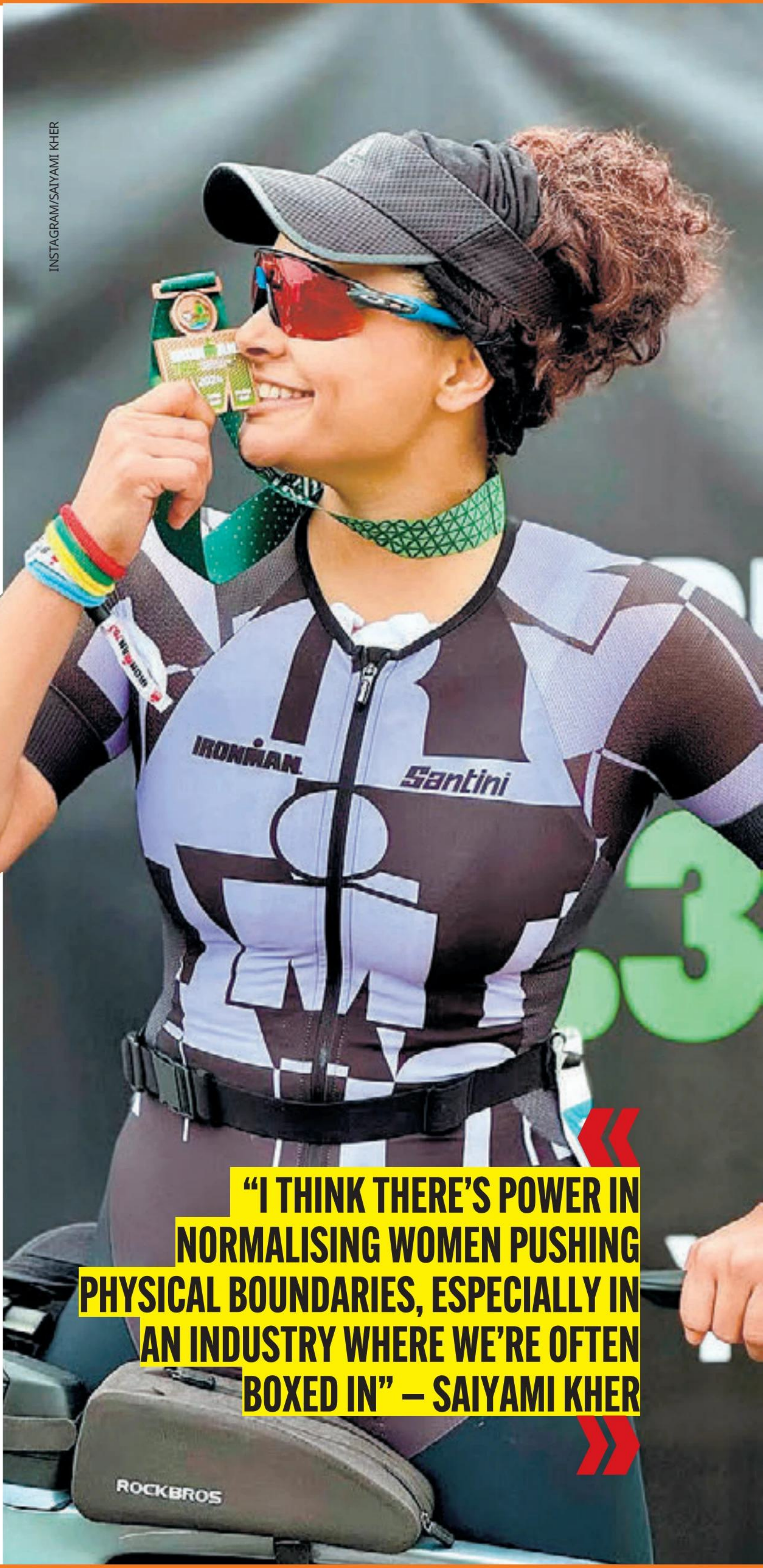
On an individual level, the reasons behind taking up these gruelling races are myriad. Neil, who has himself participated in four 70.3s and represented the country at the 70.3 World Championship, started running to leave a gloomy past far behind. "I have had quite rough teenage years when I got into drugs. I had to go to rehab at the very young age of 17. But I managed to pull myself out when I started running back in 2015. I just quit everything overnight," he says.

Prema Rajaram, a media professional from Kolkata who doubles up as a Reebok Running Squad coach, has been running since 2015. But it was only in 2024 that Prema realised what running actually meant for her in the face of a personal tragedy. "It's helped me heal after I lost my family last year. My mother, sister, and pet dog... three deaths in two months really took a toll. That's when fitness and running helped," she says.

Prema (**facing page, right below**), who has been a podium finisher at the Sohra Cherrapunji marathon and also completed a 100-km ultramarathon, plans to take on the triathlon in the coming years after improving her swim timings. **She says it is encouraging to see women starting to take care of their health.** "After years of giving time to their families and taking care of their children and the household, they are now giving themselves time to get hooked on running and fitness," she says.

What Prema says aligns with the general trend. *GeeksonFeet*, having analysed the Mumbai Marathon's attendance sheets of 2024 and 2025,

INSTAGRAM/SAIYAMI KHER



**"I THINK THERE'S POWER IN
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BOXED IN" – SAIYAMI KHER**